STEPPE

A community-owned civic commons for Redmond and Central Oregon

Governance Charter & Bylaws

Working Draft v0.1

DRAFT — NOT YET ADOPTED. This is an internal working draft prepared for revision by the founder and review by qualified Oregon nonprofit counsel. It is not a legal instrument, not legal advice, and has no force until adopted under Article XII. Bracketed items and the punch list in Schedule A mark decisions still to be confirmed.

Field	Value
Entity	Steppe (Oregon nonprofit public benefit corporation)
Governing statute	ORS Chapter 65; intended Section 501(c)(3) status
Canon basis	Business Plan v11
Base dues	$4 / month (flat)
Status	Working draft — for editing and legal review
Date	June 2026

Contents

Preamble

Steppe exists to give the people of Redmond and Central Oregon a piece of civic infrastructure they own together and cannot be sold out of. It is built on a simple wager: that a community can run its own shared space — its noticeboard, its calendar, its exchange, its conversation — without surrendering it to an attention economy that profits by extracting from the very people it claims to serve.

This Charter records how Steppe governs itself. It is written to make the organization's most important promises hard to break — entrenched in structure rather than in good intentions — while keeping the day-to-day life of the community flexible, reversible, and in the members' hands. Where this Charter constrains those who run Steppe, including its founder, that constraint is the point.

The provisions below are organized so that the load-bearing commitments — the things that make Steppe Steppe — are the hardest to change, and everything else can adapt as the community learns. *Ownership structure is destiny: a nonprofit with no owner, a locked mission, and a dissolution clause is not a detail to be revisited later but the foundation everything else rests on.*

Article I — Name, Legal Form, and Mission

1.1 Name

The name of the organization is Steppe (the "Organization" or "Steppe").

1.2 Legal form

Steppe is organized as a nonprofit public benefit corporation under the Oregon Nonprofit Corporation Act, ORS Chapter 65, and is intended to qualify as a tax-exempt organization under Section 501(c)(3) of the Internal Revenue Code. Steppe is a nonprofit from formation. It has no owners, shareholders, or members holding any equity or ownership interest; membership confers governance and participation rights only, as set out in this Charter, and never a proprietary interest in the Organization or its assets.

Steppe cannot be sold, converted to a for-profit entity, or have its assets transferred for private benefit. Its mission and its non-distribution constraint are entrenched in its Articles of Incorporation and protected by Articles III, IX, and X of this Charter.

1.3 Mission

The mission of Steppe is to build and steward community-owned civic infrastructure for the residents of Redmond and the surrounding Central Oregon region — a verified, member-governed digital commons for local information, coordination, exchange, and connection — operated for the benefit of that community and never for the extraction of value from it.

1.4 Relationship of this Charter to the Articles of Incorporation

This Charter functions as the bylaws of the Organization. Where any provision of this Charter conflicts with the Articles of Incorporation or with applicable Oregon law, the Articles and the law control. Provisions designated as Entrenched Commitments (Article III) are intended to be mirrored in, and anchored by, the Articles of Incorporation.

Article II — Definitions

In this Charter, the following terms have the meanings given below.

> **Member** — A natural person who has completed Residency Verification, paid current Dues (or holds an active Hardship Waiver), and has not been suspended or removed.
>
> **Member in Good Standing / Eligible Member** — A Member whose Dues or Waiver is current and who is not under suspension; only Eligible Members may vote and count toward Quorum.
>
> **Service Area** — The geographic area Steppe serves, initially the City of Redmond, Oregon, and such adjacent Central Oregon communities as the membership activates under Article XI.
>
> **Residency Verification** — The mandatory process by which a person establishes residency in the Service Area before becoming a Member. It is an Entrenched Commitment (Article III).
>
> **Dues** — The recurring membership fee set in Article VIII.
>
> **Board** — The Board of Directors established under Article VI.
>
> **Director** — A member of the Board.
>
> **Executive Director (ED)** — The senior staff officer engaged under contract to operate Steppe (Article VII). The ED is an employee or contractor, not an owner.
>
> **Maintainer** — A Member granted operational responsibility for a Group or feature, as defined in operating policy.
>
> **Moderator** — A Member who performs community moderation and verification-review duties and may receive honoraria under Article VIII.
>
> **Quorum** — The minimum participation required for a binding member vote (Article V).

Tenure Weight — The multiplier applied to an Eligible Member's vote based on length of continuous membership (Article V).

Ordinary Decision — A routine governance or operating decision decided by simple majority of Eligible Members voting, without a Quorum or notice requirement beyond ordinary practice.

Major Policy — A decision requiring approval by 60% of the votes cast in a vote that meets Quorum (Article V).

Foundational Decision — A decision requiring approval by 75% of the votes cast in a vote that meets Quorum, following at least 30 days' advance notice and deliberation (Article V).

Entrenched Commitment — One of the core promises listed in Article III, amendable only by Foundational Decision (or, where so anchored, not at all), and subject to the Founder Concurrence right during the Founder Protection Period.

Community Fund — The fund holding surplus and designated gifts, allocated annually by the membership through ranked-choice voting (Article VIII).

Member Access Fund — The fund that underwrites Hardship Waivers so that ability to pay never determines membership (Article VIII).

Voluntary Contribution — An optional member payment above Dues, directed by the member among permitted buckets (Article VIII).

Article III — Entrenched Commitments

The following commitments are the constitutional core of Steppe. They may be amended only by Foundational Decision under Article IX and, during the Founder Protection Period, only with Founder Concurrence under Article VII. Those anchored in the Articles of Incorporation (1.2, and the non-distribution and dissolution rules) are intended to be effectively immutable for the life of the Organization.

(a) No advertising, ever. Steppe will not sell advertising, sponsored placement, or attention. Its revenue comes from members, mission-aligned philanthropy, grants, and earned services — never from monetizing members' attention or behavior.

(b) Mandatory residency verification. Participation is limited to verified residents of the Service Area. Steppe is a place, not an open platform; verification is a permanent condition of membership, not a growth lever to be relaxed.

(c) Community-controlled governance. Ultimate authority over Steppe rests with its members through the voting framework of Article V. No founder, director, staff member, funder, or outside party may acquire controlling authority over the Organization's direction.

(d) Member-owned data. Members own their own data and content. Steppe acts as steward, not owner; it will not sell, license, or surveil member data, and members retain the right to export and to deletion as set out in operating policy.

(e) Reversible decisions. Governance is designed so that decisions can be revisited and undone by the same process that made them. Steppe favors reversible choices and preserves the community's ability to change course.

(f) Surplus serves the community. No part of Steppe's net earnings may inure to the benefit of any private individual. Operating surplus flows to the Community Fund and the mission, never to owners or insiders (Article VIII).

(g) Nonprofit form, no sale, locked mission. Steppe remains a nonprofit with no owner, cannot be sold or converted to private benefit, and on dissolution distributes its assets only to mission-aligned charitable successors (Articles I and X).

Article IV — Membership

4.1 Eligibility

Membership is open to any natural person who resides in the Service Area, completes Residency Verification, and meets the Dues obligation (or holds a Hardship Waiver). Membership is individual and non-transferable.

4.2 Residency verification

Each applicant must complete Residency Verification before being admitted. The verification process is administered by trained Moderators through Steppe's verification-review process and is governed by privacy-protective operating policy. Verification evidence is **deleted immediately upon a verification decision**; the Organization retains only the verified status, the date, and the method — never the underlying documents or identity. During the brief review window the evidence is handled only within a restricted, auto-purged review space, and it is exempt from the no-images principle that otherwise applies to community content. This mirrors the Trust & Safety / Verification decision record and the public `/privacy` and `/legal/terms` copy.

4.3 Admission

An applicant becomes a Member upon successful verification and initiation of Dues or grant of a Hardship Waiver.

4.4 Rights of members

Each Member in Good Standing has the right to:

- vote on governance matters and stand for elected roles, subject to the framework of Article V;
- propose policies, candidates, and Community Fund allocations;
- access Steppe's community features within the Service Area;
- own, export, and delete their own data and content;
- inspect the Organization's governance records and financial statements consistent with radical transparency (Article VIII); and
- leave at any time and take their data with them (4.8).

4.5 Dues obligation

Membership requires current Dues as set in Article VIII, except where a Hardship Waiver applies. Ability to pay never determines eligibility.

4.6 Good standing, lapse, and reinstatement

A Member whose Dues lapse and who holds no Waiver moves out of Good Standing and may not vote until reinstated. Reinstatement is automatic on resumption of Dues or grant of a Waiver, with no loss of accrued Tenure for the period of continuous membership preceding the lapse, subject to operating policy on extended lapses.

4.7 Suspension and removal

A Member may be suspended or removed only for conduct that violates Steppe's community standards or this Charter, and only through a process that provides notice, an opportunity to respond, and a right of appeal to the Board. Suspension and removal procedures are set in operating policy and must conform to the due-process principle stated here. Removal does not extinguish a former Member's data-export and deletion rights.

4.8 Voluntary departure and data portability

Any Member may resign at any time. On departure, the Member retains the right to export their data and to have their personal data deleted, consistent with Article III(d). Exit is a protected right; Steppe will not erect penalties or friction to discourage it.

Article V — Member Governance and Voting

5.1 Principle of member governance

Steppe is governed by its members. Elected and appointed roles exist to serve the membership and operate within the authority the members delegate; they do not displace member control over the Organization's direction (Article III(c)).

5.2 Decision tiers

Decisions are sorted into three tiers by their stakes. Higher-stakes decisions require broader agreement and more deliberation.

Tier	Threshold	Typical matters
Ordinary Decision	Simple majority of Eligible Members voting	Routine operating and policy choices not reserved to a higher tier
Major Policy	60% of votes cast, Quorum met	Significant policy changes, budgets, dues decreases, board recall
Foundational Decision	75% of votes cast, Quorum met, 30-day notice	Amending Entrenched Commitments, dues increases, dissolution, changing Article IX

5.3 Quorum

A binding Major Policy or Foundational vote requires a Quorum of at least 15% of Eligible Members participating. Ordinary Decisions do not carry a separate Quorum requirement beyond ordinary practice.

5.4 Tenure-weighted voting

To reward sustained commitment to the community without entrenching a permanent class, each Eligible Member's vote is weighted by length of continuous membership, on the following brackets. Weighting is bounded at 3×; no member's vote may exceed three times a new member's vote.

Continuous membership	Vote weight
Less than 1 year	1.0×
1 year to under 2 years	1.5×
2 years to under 4 years	2.0×
4 years and over	3.0×

5.5 Secret ballot

Member votes are cast by secret ballot. Ballots are confidential before and after a vote closes; the system is designed so that no administrator, director, or founder can link a member to their ballot. Only aggregate results and the fact of participation are recorded.

5.6 Ranked-choice for allocations

Allocations among competing options — including annual Community Fund allocation — are decided by ranked-choice voting, so that outcomes reflect the membership's ordered preferences rather than a plurality.

5.7 Proposal process

Any Member in Good Standing may bring a proposal, subject to a sponsorship or signature threshold set in operating policy to prevent flooding. Proposals state their tier, the exact change sought, and their reversibility. Foundational proposals require at least 30 days of notice and open deliberation before the vote opens. Voting windows are fixed in advance and may not be shortened once opened.

5.8 Reversibility

Consistent with Article III(e), a decision may be revisited and reversed by a later vote of the same tier. No vote may be structured to make its own reversal harder than its adoption, except where this Charter expressly assigns asymmetric protection (as in Article VIII dues).

5.9 Record and audit

Results of all binding votes are recorded in an immutable, tamper-evident audit record. Governance records are open to member inspection. The integrity of the audit record is a system-level guarantee and may not be overridden by any role.

Article VI — Board of Directors

6.1 Role

The Board stewards the mission, oversees the Executive Director, safeguards the Entrenched Commitments, and exercises the fiduciary duties Oregon law places on directors of a public benefit corporation. The Board serves the membership and operates within member-set policy.

6.2 Composition and size

The Board consists of [5–9] Directors, the exact number fixed by operating policy within that range. A majority must be Members in Good Standing. The Board includes the founder's seat as provided in 6.8 and observes the founding-cohort diversity commitments adopted by the membership.

6.3 Election and terms

Directors are elected by the membership under Article V to staggered terms of [two/three] years, so that no single election replaces the entire Board. Terms, term limits, and nomination procedures are set in operating policy consistent with this Charter.

6.4 Recall

Any Director may be recalled before the end of their term by a Major Policy vote (60% of votes cast, Quorum met). The founder's transition to an advisory seat under 6.8 is governed by Article VII, not by ordinary recall.

6.5 Powers and limits

The Board may act on all matters not reserved to the membership. It may not amend or override an Entrenched Commitment, authorize advertising, approve a sale or conversion of the Organization, distribute net earnings to any private person, or exceed the funder-concentration and compensation limits of Articles VII and VIII. Powers reserved to the membership remain with the membership.

6.6 Meetings and transparency

The Board meets on a regular schedule. Minutes, decisions, and financial oversight materials are made available to members consistent with the radical-transparency standard of Article VIII, subject only to narrow confidentiality for personnel, legal, and verification-privacy matters.

6.7 Conflicts of interest

Directors must disclose actual and potential conflicts of interest and recuse themselves from affected decisions. Relationships between Directors and entities that contract with Steppe — including the founder's outside consulting work — must be disclosed and managed under a written conflict-of-interest policy.

6.8 Founder's board seat and transition

The founder holds a Director seat during the Founder Protection Period. At or before the end of that Period, the founder's seat converts to a permanent, non-voting advisory seat, as detailed in Article VII. The transition is a structural feature of this Charter, not a discretionary act of the Board.

Article VII — Executive Director and Founder Protection

7.1 Executive Director

The Executive Director operates Steppe day-to-day under the Board's oversight, pursuant to a contract. The ED is an employee or contractor of the Organization and holds no ownership interest of any kind. The role exists to serve the mission and the membership.

7.2 Founding Executive Director

The founder may serve as the Founding Executive Director under contract. This role is compensated service, not ownership or control. Nothing in the founder's role diminishes the membership's ultimate authority under Article III(c).

7.3 Compensation framework

Executive Director compensation is bounded and transparent. It moves through phases tied to the Organization's capacity, with a hard ceiling set deliberately below comparable academic and market salaries as a signal of public trust.

Phase	Annual compensation
Founding / pre-revenue	$0 (volunteer)
Early operations	$15,000 – $25,000 stipend
Sustained operations	$95,000 ceiling (hard cap)

Cost-of-living adjustments to the ceiling are capped at 3% annually. Any increase above the ceiling, or any change to this framework, is a Major Policy decision and must be disclosed under Article VIII.

7.4 Founder Protection Period

To protect the integrity of the mission during Steppe's formative years, a Founder Protection Period runs from adoption of this Charter for [five to seven] years and then sunsets automatically. The exact length is fixed at adoption and may not be extended except by Foundational Decision.

7.5 Founder Concurrence right (negative power only)

During the Founder Protection Period, the following actions require the founder's concurrence in addition to the otherwise-required member or Board approval:

- amending or repealing an Entrenched Commitment (Article III);
- dissolving, merging, or selling the Organization or substantially all of its assets (Article X); and
- lowering the amendment thresholds of Article IX, including this concurrence right itself.

This is a negative power only. The founder may withhold concurrence to block one of the listed changes, but may not use it to compel any action, direct ordinary governance, override a member or Board decision outside the listed set, or otherwise exercise positive control. It is not a general veto, not an ownership interest, and not a controlling authority within the meaning of Article III(c).

7.6 Sunset and transition to advisory

At the end of the Founder Protection Period, the Concurrence right expires permanently and the founder's Director seat converts to a permanent, non-voting advisory seat (6.8). The sunset is automatic and self-executing; no vote is required to end the Period, and the Period may be extended only by Foundational Decision before it lapses.

Legal-review flag. A founder concurrence right inside a member-governed nonprofit with no owner sits in tension with the no-controlling-authority principle (Article III(c)) and with Oregon nonprofit governance norms. Counsel must structure this as a narrow, time-limited reserved power in the bylaws and confirm it is compatible with ORS Chapter 65 and 501(c)(3), or propose an alternative mechanism that achieves mission protection without conferring control. See Schedule A.

Article VIII — Dues, Funds, and Finances

8.1 Dues

Base Dues are $4 per month (flat), the same for every Member regardless of means. To minimize payment-processing cost, Dues are billed annually or by ACH where practicable. The flat price reflects Steppe's commitment to one fair price near cost, never a fee scaled to what a member can be made to pay.

8.2 Asymmetric dues protection

Changes to base Dues are deliberately protected asymmetrically: raising the price is hard, lowering it is easier. This makes the member-affordability promise structurally difficult to erode while keeping relief easy to grant.

Change to base Dues	Required process
Increase	Foundational Decision — 75% of votes cast, Quorum met, 30-day notice
Decrease	Major Policy — 60% of votes cast, Quorum met

8.3 Hardship Waiver

Any Member may receive a Hardship Waiver of Dues on request, without documentation and without inquiry into their circumstances. Waivers are funded by the Member Access Fund. A Member on Waiver is a full Member in Good Standing with full voting rights.

8.4 Voluntary Contribution layer

Above base Dues, Members may make optional Voluntary Contributions and direct each contribution among three buckets: (i) unrestricted operations, (ii) the Member Access Fund, and (iii) the Community Fund. Contributions are never required and never affect a Member's standing or rights.

8.5 Member Access Fund

The Member Access Fund underwrites Hardship Waivers so that ability to pay never determines membership (Article III). It is replenished by designated Voluntary Contributions and, as the Board directs, by operating surplus.

8.6 Community Fund

Operating surplus and gifts designated to it flow to the Community Fund. Each year the membership allocates the Community Fund among community priorities by ranked-choice vote (Article V). Allocation is collective: no individual may earmark a Community Fund gift to a specific recipient, and the Organization makes no individual charity designations on members' behalf.

8.7 Funding model and concentration limit

Steppe is funded by five streams: member Dues (the anchor of core operations), philanthropic donations, foundation grants, government funding (anticipated from 2028), and earned revenue from mission-aligned services. To preserve independence, no single funder may provide more than 30% of annual operating revenue.

8.8 Surplus and non-distribution

Steppe operates on a non-distribution constraint. No part of its net earnings may inure to the benefit of any Director, officer, ED, Member, or other private individual. Surplus serves the mission through the Community Fund and the Member Access Fund (Article III(f)).

8.9 Moderator honoraria

Active Moderators may receive honoraria of $50–$100 per month in recognition of their labor. Total Moderator honoraria are capped at 8% of operating expenses. **[Amendment pending — see Operating Budget §4: the flat 8%-of-opex cap cannot fund the promised three-moderator floor at early stages; to be amended to "the greater of the $1,800/yr floor or 8% of core opex, capped at $100/mo/moderator, grant-funded until Stage 2."]** Moderators serve staggered, one-year renewable terms, with a minimum of three active Moderators to preserve plural judgment and prevent capture.

8.10 Financial transparency

Steppe practices radical financial transparency. It publishes its budget, financial statements, funder breakdown, compensation against the Article VII framework, and Community Fund allocations to its members on a regular cadence, subject only to narrow privacy exceptions.

Article IX — Amendments

9.1 Tiered amendment

This Charter is amended through the same tiered framework that governs all Steppe decisions (Article V). The tier required depends on what is being changed.

9.2 Matters requiring a Foundational Decision

The following may be changed only by Foundational Decision (75% of votes cast, Quorum met, 30-day notice):

- any Entrenched Commitment (Article III);
- an increase to base Dues (Article VIII);
- the compensation ceiling framework or Founder Protection provisions (Article VII);
- this Article IX, including any change to amendment thresholds; and
- dissolution, merger, or sale (Article X).

All other policy amendments are Major Policy or Ordinary Decisions according to their stakes.

9.3 Notice and deliberation

Foundational amendments require at least 30 days of advance notice and open deliberation before voting opens, so that the membership can consider them fully.

9.4 Founder Concurrence during the Protection Period

During the Founder Protection Period, amendments within the scope of Article 7.5 additionally require Founder Concurrence. This requirement itself sunsets with the Period.

9.5 Limits on amendment

No amendment may reduce an amendment threshold except by meeting that same threshold; no amendment may remove the non-distribution constraint or the dissolution rule, which are anchored in the Articles of Incorporation; and no amendment may confer ownership of, or controlling authority over, the Organization on any person (Article III(c)).

Article X — Dissolution

10.1 Process

Steppe may be dissolved only by Foundational Decision and in accordance with ORS Chapter 65 and applicable federal tax law. During the Founder Protection Period, dissolution also requires Founder Concurrence (Article 7.5).

10.2 Distribution of assets

On dissolution, after satisfying liabilities, Steppe's remaining assets must be distributed exclusively to one or more organizations that are exempt under Section 501(c)(3) and whose purposes are consistent with Steppe's mission, as the membership directs. No asset may be distributed to any Member, Director, officer, ED, or other private person.

10.3 Mission lock

This dissolution rule and the non-distribution constraint are anchored in the Articles of Incorporation and are not amendable in a manner that would permit private benefit. They are the ultimate guarantee that Steppe cannot be captured or cashed out.

Article XI — Regional Expansion (Deferred Activation)

11.1 Subsidiarity

Steppe is built to grow into a federation of local commons across Central Oregon without becoming centralized. Decisions that affect only one town are made by that town's members; only genuinely regional matters rise to a regional vote. Local control is the default.

11.2 Structural principles locked now

The structural principles of regional governance are adopted now and may be changed only by Foundational Decision: (a) subsidiarity scope tiers that keep local decisions local; and (b) a dual-majority requirement for regional decisions, so that a measure must carry both an overall majority and a majority within each affected town.

11.3 Numeric dials deferred

The specific numeric parameters of regional governance — tier boundaries, dual-majority percentages, and representation formulas — are deferred and will be ratified by the membership once Steppe has active members in two or more qualifying towns. Until then, this Article states principle only and is not operative as to numbers.

Article XII — Adoption, Effective Date, and Review

12.1 Adoption

This Charter takes effect when adopted by the founding membership in accordance with the Articles of Incorporation and, pending a founding membership vote, when approved by the initial Board. Until adoption, it has no binding force.

12.2 Effective date

The effective date is the date of adoption recorded below, which also begins the Founder Protection Period (Article VII).

12.3 Periodic review

The Board will place this Charter before the membership for review at least once every [three] years, so that the community can confirm or revise it through the normal amendment process.

12.4 Severability

If any provision of this Charter is held invalid or unenforceable, the remaining provisions continue in effect, and the invalid provision is reformed to the minimum extent necessary to be valid while preserving its intent.

12.5 Governing law

This Charter is governed by the laws of the State of Oregon and must be read consistently with the Articles of Incorporation, ORS Chapter 65, and the requirements of Section 501(c)(3).

Adopted on: __________________________

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Founding Executive Director

____

Board Chair, on behalf of the Board of Directors

Schedule A — Open Drafting Questions & Legal-Review Flags

This schedule is not part of the operative Charter. It is a working punch list of items to confirm before adoption and to raise with Oregon nonprofit counsel.

Decisions to confirm (bracketed in the text)

- Founder Protection Period length: fix the exact term within five to seven years (7.4).
- Board size and term length: confirm the 5–9 range and term/stagger (6.2, 6.3).
- Charter review cadence: confirm the review interval (12.3).
- Proposal sponsorship/signature thresholds: set in operating policy (5.7).

Legal-review flags for counsel

- Founder Concurrence right (7.5): confirm a narrow, time-limited negative reserved power is enforceable under ORS Chapter 65 and compatible with 501(c)(3) and with the no-controlling-authority commitment (III(c)); or propose an alternative mission-protection mechanism.
- Entrenchment mechanics: confirm which commitments belong in the Articles of Incorporation versus the bylaws, and how to make the Article III set genuinely hard to amend under Oregon law.
- Asymmetric dues protection (8.2): confirm a bylaws-level supermajority-to-raise / majority-to-lower rule is enforceable and consistent with member-rights provisions.
- Tenure-weighted voting (5.4): confirm weighted member voting is permissible for an Oregon public benefit corporation with members and is reflected correctly in the Articles.
- Compensation ceiling (7.3): confirm the framework satisfies reasonable-compensation and private-inurement rules; document the basis.
- Dissolution and non-distribution (Article X): confirm the asset-distribution clause meets 501(c)(3) requirements.

Not legal advice. This document was prepared as a working draft to support the founder's editing and a subsequent review by qualified Oregon nonprofit counsel. It does not constitute legal advice and creates no rights or obligations until properly adopted.
